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Mine Dump Hearing Up in Air

By DON VIPOND

William Venables, B.C.'s director of pollution control, said today he can't say yet whether he will hold a public hearing on a mining company's application to discharge tailings near a Jordan River beach.

But his decision on whether to hold a hearing will not be based on demands from protesters for one, he said, but on whether he thinks a hearing would produce information helpful in making a decision on the application.

"It has to be pertinent information, not just flag-waving protests."

The application in question is from Dison Development Ltd. to dump up to a million gallons of mine tailings a day at a beach near Jordan River.

Residents in the area are protesting and the Capital Regional Board will too if certain conditions aren't met.

Venables said such applications get detailed scrutiny from the pollution control branch and consideration by four other government departments before they reach his desk for a decision, including whether a hearing will be called.

That point hasn't been reached with the Dison application so he can't say about a hearing. It's an involved assessment process which can take up to 120 days, he said.

He took the occasion to comment generally on pollution control efforts in B.C. and the protection the act he works under affords the public which he suggested are not generally understood.

Among the points he made:

- Disposal permits set out the specific standards a company must meet and the branch monitors the system to ensure they are met.
- He has the authority to stiffen (but not to liberalize) these standards if subsequent testing shows it's warranted.

Does that mean if the Utah mining operation, for example, proves more harmful to Rupert Inlet than originally anticipated, he can force the company to improve its system of effluent discharge?

Definitely, he said. The standards could be changed to the point where any company had to spend a good deal of money to meet them.

"We have good control of these permits."

Venables said B.C.'s Pollution Control Act is one of the finest pieces of such legislation there is and people in the province should be pleased and proud of it.

Pollution control, like everything else, takes time, he said. The amount of "lead time" needed is one of the biggest problems.

All the parties involved — the people, himself, government and industry — require time to make it work.

Mate-Hungry Nootka Sold to U.S.

Sealand director Bob Wright completed negotiations with the Japanese Deer Park near Los Angeles Friday for the sale of the female killer whale Nootka.

She will be shipped by a freight plane Wednesday morning.

The decision to sell Nootka was made two months after the other female killer whale in the pool, the albino Chimo, developed a skin condition.

Chimo has been getting massive extra daily doses of vitamins in the belief that she could be suffering from a vitamin deficiency.

Another cause of Chimo's condition may be tension caused by the aggressive attitude of Nootka

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Experts believe that Nootka, about seven years of age, is now sexually mature. Her domination of the pool, they say, is caused by frustration because Sealand's male killer whale Haida is too young to respond.

The albino, much more delicate, appears to be slowly responding to treatment but Wright says there is too much risk involved if Nootka remains.

"I've promised the minister of fisheries and others that the white whale will remain in Canada.

"Nootka is a great performing animal and I hate to see her go. But when even her own trainer advises we do this — there's really no choice to be made."

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The California company is building a $7 million underwater complex at Arlington, Texas, with a refrigerated whale pool. When it is completed, Nootka will be moved there.

Suspicions that Nootka is ready to mate were fanned again Friday morning when a

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